SUPREMACY OF THEOCRACY

Iran is an Islamic Republic that is dominated by a theocracy based on the doctrine of Velayat-e Faqih (Guardianship of the Islamic Jurist)

THE SUPREME LEADER

The highest and ultimate authority in Iran, he is commander-in-chief of the armed forces, controls the judiciary, appoints heads of top state bodies like the Guardian Council. He is selected by the Assembly of Experts, a body of 88 Islamic clerics—elected by the public from a list vetted by the Guardian Council. The assembly can select, supervise and even dismiss the Supreme Leader. After Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's death, this body is overseeing succession

THE THEOCRACY

THE GUARDIAN COUNCIL

The 12-member council vets all politicians in parliament, the Assembly of Experts and ensures rule by Islamic principles. Six are clerics chosen by the Supreme Leader; six are legal scholars selected by parliament

EXPEDIENCY COUNCIL

An advisory body of clerics, soldiers, former presidents etc appointed by the Supreme Leader. It resolves disputes between parliament and the Guardian Council

ASSEMBLY OF EXPERTS

Composed of clerics elected by the public, but only after the Guardian Council's vetting. Responsible for appointing and supervising the Supreme Leader

THE EXECUTIVE

PRESIDENT

(Masoud Pezeshkian, elected in July 2024)

The President is elected by popular vote after the Guardian Council vets the candidates. He serves a four-year term and is responsible for day-to-day governance. But real power rests with the Supreme Leader

THE LEGISLATURE

MAJLIS (PARLIAMENT)

(Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, Speaker, elected in May 2020)

Legislature of 290 MPs elected for 4-year terms through national polls dominated by clerics and former IRGC members. Has powers to legislate, approve budgets and ratify international agreements

THE JUDICIARY

Structured under a Chief Justice, who is traditionally appointed by the Supreme Leader and influenced by him, the judiciary oversees courts, enforces laws, and handles legal proceedings





Appointed or approved

Directly elected

ARMED FORCES

ISLAMIC REVOLUTIONARY GUARD CORPS (IRGC)

It is a powerful armed force parallel to the army and known for its loyalty to the Supreme Leader. It currently controls around 40 per cent of Iran's economy, with interests in agriculture, energy and finance, offering employment to millions. It controls the following:

↘ **BASIJ MILITIA** for internal policing and quelling dissent

↘ **QUDS FORCE** oversees operations abroad, including nurturing allies like the Hezbollah in Lebanon, Hamas in Palestine and the Houthis in Yemen

↘ It controls Iran's ballistic missile programme, protects its nuclear facilities

TOPPLING THE TOP ECHELON

Key Iranian leaders killed in the February 28 air strike in Tehran by Israel



AYATOLLAH ALI KHAMENEI
Supreme Leader of Iran since 1989



ALI SHAMKHANI
Top advisor to Khamenei, Defence Council Secretary



GEN. ABDOLRAHIM MOUSAVI
Chief of Staff of Armed Forces



GEN. MOHAMMAD PAKPOUR
Commander, IRGC



AMIR NASIRZADEH
Defence Minister